SERVICENOW PROJECT DOCUMENTATION — PHASE 3

3. Project Planning Phase

Automating Employee Data Import in ServiceNow

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Section 1 — Introduction to Project Planning Phase

1. Introduction to Project Planning Phase

The Project Planning Phase is one of the most critical stages in the software development and systems implementation lifecycle. It serves as the structured bridge between understanding the project's requirements and beginning the actual technical implementation. Without thorough and well-documented planning, even technically sound solutions risk being delivered late, over budget, or misaligned with the original business objectives.

In the context of software development, project planning encompasses several interconnected activities: defining the scope of the work to be performed, establishing measurable objectives, identifying and scheduling deliverables, allocating resources, estimating timelines, and anticipating potential risks that may arise during execution. Each of these activities contributes to building a coherent and actionable roadmap that guides the project team from inception to completion.

For a ServiceNow implementation project such as Automating Employee Data Import, the planning phase is particularly important because the project involves multiple interdependent components — including Import Sets, Transform Maps, Dot Walking, and Dictionary Override — each of which must be configured and tested in a specific sequence. A well-defined project plan ensures that these components are addressed in the correct order, that dependencies between tasks are clearly identified, and that the project team has a shared understanding of what needs to be accomplished at each stage.

Proper planning also contributes to efficient resource utilization. By identifying the tools, skills, and access permissions required before implementation begins, the project team can ensure that all prerequisites are in place before technical work commences, preventing delays caused by missing resources or unresolved access issues. Furthermore, a documented project plan provides a

reference point against which progress can be measured throughout the project, enabling timely identification of deviations and facilitating corrective action where necessary.

This section of the documentation presents the complete project plan for the Automating Employee Data Import project, covering the project scope, objectives, deliverables, timeline, resource requirements, risk management strategies, and planned workflow.

Section 2 — Project Overview

2. Project Overview

This project addresses a significant operational challenge faced by organizations that rely on ServiceNow for incident management and IT service delivery. In many enterprise environments, employee data — including names, email addresses, departmental affiliations, and managerial hierarchies — is maintained in external systems such as Microsoft Excel spreadsheets or Google Sheets. When this data is required within ServiceNow, the absence of an automated import mechanism forces administrators to manually enter or update records, introducing substantial risks of error, inconsistency, and data currency issues.

The project implements an end-to-end automated solution that enables the bulk import of employee records from structured external files into the ServiceNow User table (sys_user). Once imported, this employee data becomes accessible across the ServiceNow platform, most notably within the Incident Management module, where it enables the automatic display of an affected user's department and manager information directly within incident records. This enhanced data availability improves the speed and accuracy of incident routing, escalation, and resolution.

2.1 Key Project Components

- Import Sets: ServiceNow's native data staging mechanism used to receive and hold imported employee data prior to transformation.

- Transform Maps: Configuration objects that define the field-level mappings between the Import Set staging table and the sys_user target table.
- Dot Walking: A ServiceNow technique that traverses reference field relationships to automatically retrieve and display related data, such as manager email, within incident forms.
- Dictionary Override: A ServiceNow configuration mechanism used to customize field-level attributes, such as changing the default priority value for incident records.

2.2 Expected Project Outcome

Upon successful completion, the project will deliver a fully configured and tested automated import solution within ServiceNow. Administrators will be able to import employee records by uploading a single structured data file, after which all records will be automatically transformed and stored in the ServiceNow User table with correct field mappings and resolved relational references. Incident Management Agents will benefit from enriched incident records that automatically display department names and manager email addresses for affected users, significantly reducing the time required to route and escalate incidents appropriately.

Section 3 — Project Scope

3. Project Scope

The project scope defines the boundaries of the work to be performed, clearly establishing what is included within the project and what falls outside its remit. A well-defined scope prevents scope creep, ensures that team members focus their efforts on the agreed deliverables, and provides stakeholders with a clear understanding of what to expect upon project completion.

3.1 In-Scope Activities

The following activities and deliverables are explicitly included within the scope of this project:

In-Scope Item	Description
Employee Data File Preparation	Preparing a structured employee data file in Microsoft Excel (.xlsx) or CSV format, containing the following fields: Name, Email, Department, Manager, and Manager Email. The file will be prepared in Google Sheets or Microsoft Excel and exported in the appropriate format for import into ServiceNow.
ServiceNow Import Set Configuration	Creating and configuring a dedicated Import Set in ServiceNow to serve as the staging area for incoming employee data. This includes uploading the data file, generating the Import Set table, and verifying that all records and columns are correctly loaded.
Transform Map Setup and Field Mapping	Creating a Transform Map within ServiceNow that defines the field-level correspondence between the Import Set staging table and the sys_user target table. All required fields — Name, Email, Department, Manager, and Manager Email — will be mapped, including the designation of the email field as a coalesce key to prevent duplicate records.
Dot Walking Implementation in Incident Forms	Configuring Dot Walking expressions within the Transform Map to automatically retrieve and display the Department name and Manager Email from referenced records in related ServiceNow tables. These values will be made available within the Incident Management form for affected users.
Dictionary Override Configuration	Applying a Dictionary Override to the Priority field of the Incident table (or other specified field) to customize the default priority value in accordance with the organization's incident management policy.
Solution Testing and Validation	Executing the complete import and transformation process in a test environment and validating that all imported records are accurately reflected in the sys_user table with all required fields correctly populated.
Project Documentation	Producing comprehensive project documentation covering all phases from requirement analysis through implementation and testing, as required for academic or professional project submission.

3.2 Out-of-Scope Activities

The following activities are explicitly excluded from the scope of this project to maintain focus and prevent scope creep:

- Integration with external HR systems or third-party identity management platforms.
- Custom scripting using ServiceNow's GlideScript or Business Rules beyond the standard configuration tools used in this project.
- Configuration of ServiceNow notification workflows or email alert mechanisms.
- User interface customization of the ServiceNow incident form beyond the display of Dot-Walked fields.
- Migration of historical incident data or retrospective updates to existing incident records.
- End-user training programs or training material development for the organization's broader ServiceNow user base.

Section 4 — Project Objectives

4. Project Objectives

Project objectives define the specific, measurable outcomes that the project aims to achieve. Clear objectives provide direction for all implementation activities, serve as criteria for evaluating the success of the project upon completion, and ensure alignment between the project team's efforts and the broader organizational goals.

4.1 Primary Objectives

Obj. ID	Objective Statement	Priority
OBJ-01	Automate the employee data import process into ServiceNow, eliminating the need for manual data entry by administrators and reducing the administrative burden associated with maintaining accurate employee records.	High
OBJ-02	Improve the accuracy and consistency of employee data stored in the ServiceNow User table by implementing a structured, repeatable import process with built-in coalesce-based duplicate prevention.	High
OBJ-03	Enable the automatic display of department name and manager email address within ServiceNow incident records through the implementation of Dot Walking, providing Incident Management Agents with immediate access to critical employee information.	High
OBJ-04	Enhance the overall efficiency of incident management operations in ServiceNow by ensuring that all relevant employee information is available directly within the incident form, reducing the time agents spend manually locating and verifying employee details.	High
OBJ-05	Configure Dictionary Override to align the default incident priority with organizational policy, reducing the frequency of manual priority adjustments during incident creation.	Medium
OBJ-06	Establish a reusable and well-documented import framework that can be applied to future employee data refresh operations without requiring reconfiguration of the core Transform Map or field mapping settings.	Medium

4.2 Success Criteria

The project will be considered successfully completed when all of the following success criteria are met:

1. All employee records from the source data file are successfully imported into the sys_user table with zero unresolved errors in the final transformation log.
2. All five required fields — Name, Email, Department, Manager, and Manager Email — are correctly populated in every imported user record.

3. The Department name and Manager Email are correctly retrieved and displayed in the incident form for affected users through Dot Walking, without requiring manual input.
4. The Dictionary Override configuration is active and the default priority value on the Incident table reflects the customized value as specified.
5. The import process can be successfully repeated using a new data file without requiring any modifications to the Transform Map configuration.
6. All project documentation is complete, professionally formatted, and suitable for submission.

Section 5 — Project Deliverables

5. Project Deliverables

Project deliverables are the tangible outputs and artifacts that will be produced during the course of the project and handed over upon its completion. Each deliverable represents a distinct, verifiable output that contributes to the overall project objective and can be reviewed against the project's acceptance criteria.

Del. ID	Deliverable Description	Phase
DEL-01	Employee Data File: A structured Microsoft Excel (.xlsx) or CSV data file containing all employee records to be imported into ServiceNow. The file will include the following columns: Name, Email, Department, Manager, and Manager Email, formatted in accordance with the requirements of the ServiceNow Import Sets module.	Preparation
DEL-02	Import Set Configuration: A fully configured and functional Import Set within the ServiceNow platform, comprising the staging table (u_employee_import) loaded with all employee records from the source data file, verified to contain the correct	Implementation

Del. ID	Deliverable Description	Phase
	number of records and columns.	
DEL-03	Transform Map Setup: A completed Transform Map configuration within ServiceNow that defines all required field mappings between the Import Set staging table and the sys_user target table, including the designation of the email field as the coalesce key for duplicate prevention.	Implementation
DEL-04	Dot Walking Implementation: Configured Dot Walking expressions within the Transform Map's field mappings that enable the automatic retrieval and display of Department Name and Manager Email from referenced records in related ServiceNow tables, verified to function correctly within the incident form.	Implementation
DEL-05	Dictionary Override Configuration: A successfully applied Dictionary Override on the specified field of the Incident table, customizing the default priority value as required. Verification documentation confirming that the override is active and functioning correctly.	Implementation
DEL-06	Testing and Validation Report: A documented validation of the complete import process, confirming that all employee records have been correctly imported, all fields are accurately populated, and all configured features function as expected. Any errors encountered during testing and the corrective actions taken will be recorded.	Testing
DEL-07	Final Project Documentation: Comprehensive, professionally formatted documentation covering all project phases, including the Identification Phase, Requirement Analysis, Project Planning Phase, Implementation Phase, and Testing Phase. The documentation will be suitable for academic or professional project submission.	Documentation

Section 6 — Project Timeline

6. Project Timeline

The project timeline defines the estimated sequence and duration of each project phase, providing a structured schedule that guides the team's activities from initiation to final delivery. The timeline is designed to be realistic and achievable, with sufficient time allocated for each phase to ensure quality outcomes, while maintaining momentum toward the project's completion.

The project is organized into five sequential phases, each building upon the work completed in the previous phase. The timeline presented below reflects estimated durations appropriate for an academic or professional implementation project of this scope.

#	Phase / Activity	Duration	Est. Duration	Key Deliverable
1	**Requirement Analysis**	Week 1	5–7 Days	Approved requirements document covering business, functional, non-functional, and user requirements.
2	**Project Planning**	Week 2	4–5 Days	Completed Project Planning document including scope, objectives, deliverables, timeline, resources, and risk register.
3	**Implementation Phase**	Weeks 3–4	8–10 Days	Fully configured Import Set, Transform Map, Dot Walking expressions, and Dictionary Override within ServiceNow.
4	**Testing Phase**	Week 5	4–5 Days	Validated import results, testing report documenting outcomes and any corrective actions taken.
5	**Documentation and Final Review**	Week 6	3–4 Days	Complete, formatted, and reviewed final project documentation package ready for submission.

6.1 Phase Descriptions

Phase 1: Requirement Analysis (Week 1)

During the Requirement Analysis phase, all project requirements are gathered, documented, and reviewed. This phase involves stakeholder consultation, review of existing data management processes, and formal documentation of business, functional, non-functional, user, and system requirements. The phase concludes with the production and approval of the Requirement Analysis document.

Phase 2: Project Planning (Week 2)

The Project Planning phase produces this document, establishing the framework for the entire project. Activities include defining the project scope, setting measurable objectives, listing deliverables, building the project timeline, identifying resource requirements, and conducting an initial risk assessment. The completed Project Planning document serves as the authoritative reference for all subsequent project activities.

Phase 3: Implementation Phase (Weeks 3–4)

The Implementation Phase is the most technically intensive phase of the project. Activities are performed in the following sequence: preparation of the employee data file, loading of data into ServiceNow using the Import Sets module, creation and configuration of the Transform Map, implementation of Dot Walking expressions for derived fields, and application of the Dictionary Override to the specified field. Each activity is completed and briefly tested before proceeding to the next.

Phase 4: Testing Phase (Week 5)

The Testing Phase involves the systematic validation of all implemented components. The complete import and transformation process is executed, and the results are verified against the acceptance criteria defined in the project objectives. Any discrepancies or errors are identified, corrected, and re-tested. A testing report is produced documenting the outcomes of all test cases.

Phase 5: Documentation and Final Review (Week 6)

The final phase involves the compilation, formatting, and review of all project documentation. All phase documents are reviewed for completeness, accuracy, and professional presentation. Final corrections are applied, and the completed documentation package is prepared for submission.

Section 7 — Resource Planning

7. Resource Planning

Resource planning identifies and documents all resources required to successfully execute the project. Resources encompass platform access, hardware and software tools, technical skills, and human resources. Ensuring that all required resources are available and accessible before the implementation phase begins is essential for preventing delays and maintaining project momentum.

7.1 Technical Resources

Resource	Specification and Purpose
ServiceNow Platform Access	A licensed and operational ServiceNow instance is required throughout the project. A Personal Developer Instance (PDI), which is freely available through the ServiceNow Developer Program, is suitable for this project. The implementing user must hold the admin role within the instance to access the Import Sets, Transform Maps, Dictionary, and Incident Management modules.
Computer System with Internet Access	A personal computer or laptop running a modern operating system (Windows, macOS, or Linux) with a stable internet connection is required to access the cloud-based ServiceNow platform. A minimum recommended browser specification of Google Chrome (version 90+), Mozilla Firefox (version 88+), or Microsoft Edge (version 90+) is required for consistent platform functionality.

Resource	Specification and Purpose
Spreadsheet Software	Google Sheets (accessible via a standard web browser) or Microsoft Excel (version 2016 or later) is required for the preparation, editing, and export of the employee data file. The software must support export of files in XLSX or CSV format for compatibility with the ServiceNow Import Sets module.
Text or Documentation Editor	A word processing application such as Microsoft Word, Google Docs, or LibreOffice Writer is required for the production of project documentation. The application must support professional document formatting including headings, tables, paragraph styles, and pagination.

7.2 Technical Skills and Knowledge Requirements

Skill Area	Description and Required Proficiency Level
ServiceNow Platform Navigation	Proficiency in navigating the ServiceNow interface, including accessing and working within the System Import Sets, System Definition, User Administration, and Incident Management modules. Intermediate-level proficiency is required.
ServiceNow Import Sets	Understanding of the Import Sets module, including the process of uploading data files, creating Import Set tables, and initiating transformation operations. Intermediate-level proficiency is required.
Transform Map Configuration	Ability to create Transform Maps, define Field Map entries, configure coalesce fields, and execute data transformation operations. Intermediate-level proficiency is required.
Dot Walking Syntax	Understanding of ServiceNow's Dot Walking syntax and the ability to construct Dot Walk expressions to traverse reference field relationships across related tables. Intermediate-level proficiency is required.
Dictionary Override	Knowledge of ServiceNow's Dictionary Override mechanism, including the ability to create and apply overrides to customize field-level attributes on a per-table basis. Foundational-level proficiency is required.

Skill Area	Description and Required Proficiency Level
Data Preparation in Spreadsheets	Ability to create, format, and export structured tabular data in Google Sheets or Microsoft Excel, including the correct naming of column headers and formatting of data values. Foundational-level proficiency is required.

7.3 Human Resources

For an academic or individual project implementation, the following human resource roles and responsibilities are identified:

- Project Lead / Implementer: Responsible for all technical implementation activities, including data preparation, ServiceNow configuration, testing, and validation. This role requires the full range of technical skills described in Section 7.2.
- Document Author: Responsible for producing and formatting all project documentation in accordance with the documentation standards established for this project. For an individual project, this role is typically fulfilled by the same person as the Project Lead.
- Reviewer / Supervisor: Responsible for reviewing completed documentation and implementation artifacts against the project's acceptance criteria. In an academic context, this role is typically fulfilled by the project supervisor or assessor.

Section 8 — Risk Management

8. Risk Management

Risk management is a systematic process of identifying, analysing, and responding to risks that may affect the project's ability to achieve its objectives. Effective risk management does not eliminate risk entirely, but rather ensures that the project team is aware of potential threats, has

assessed their likelihood and impact, and has prepared appropriate mitigation strategies to minimize their effect on the project.

The following risk register documents the key risks identified during the Project Planning Phase, along with their assessed impact level and recommended mitigation strategies.

8.1 Risk Register

Risk ID	Risk Description	Impact Level	Mitigation Strategy
R-01	Incorrect or inconsistent formatting in the employee data file, such as misaligned columns, missing headers, or unsupported data types, may cause the Import Set to load data incorrectly or fail entirely.	**High**	Develop and distribute a standardized import file template with clear column header definitions. Conduct a pre-import data review to validate the file structure before uploading to ServiceNow.
R-02	Field mapping errors in the Transform Map may result in data being mapped to incorrect target fields, producing inaccurate employee records in the sys_user table.	**High**	Thoroughly review all field mappings before executing the transformation in the production environment. Conduct initial transformation tests using a small subset of records in a development instance to verify mapping accuracy.
R-03	Missing or non-existent Department or Manager records in ServiceNow at the time of import may prevent the correct resolution of reference fields through Dot Walking, resulting in empty or	**High**	Verify that all Department records exist in the cmn_department table and all Manager records exist in the sys_user table prior to initiating the employee data import. Create any missing records before running the transformation.

Risk ID	Risk Description	Impact Level	Mitigation Strategy
	unresolved field values.		
R-04	Insufficient or incorrectly configured access permissions in ServiceNow may prevent the project implementer from accessing the Import Sets, Transform Maps, or Dictionary modules required for the implementation.	**Medium**	Confirm that the implementing user holds the admin role in ServiceNow before commencing implementation. Request elevated permissions from the instance owner if necessary, providing sufficient lead time to avoid delays.
R-05	Large volumes of employee records in the import file may cause processing delays or upload timeouts when submitted through the ServiceNow Import Sets interface.	**Medium**	Divide large data files into smaller batches of manageable size (e.g., 200–500 records per batch) for import. Schedule large-volume import operations during off-peak usage periods to minimize platform impact.
R-06	Dictionary Override may inadvertently affect field behavior across the entire Incident table, impacting other fields or users beyond the intended scope of the customization.	**Medium**	Review the Dictionary Override configuration carefully before saving to confirm that it is scoped to the correct table and field. Test the override in a development environment before applying it to the production instance.
R-07	Disruption to internet connectivity during an active data upload or transformation operation may result in an incomplete or failed import process.	**Low**	Ensure a stable and reliable internet connection is available throughout all import and configuration activities. In the event of a connectivity disruption, the import process can be re-initiated once connectivity is restored, as the coalesce configuration will prevent duplicate records.

8.2 Risk Response Summary

The risk management strategy for this project is primarily prevention-focused, emphasizing proactive measures to reduce the likelihood of risks materializing. Where risks cannot be entirely prevented, the mitigation strategies described in the risk register ensure that their impact on the project can be minimised and that recovery is achievable without significant rework or delay. All identified risks will be monitored throughout the implementation phase, and the risk register will be updated if new risks are identified or if the assessed impact level of existing risks changes.

Section 9 — Project Workflow

9. Project Workflow

The project workflow defines the planned sequence of technical activities that will be carried out during the Implementation Phase of the project. The workflow is presented as an ordered series of steps, each building directly upon the outputs of the preceding step. Following this workflow ensures that all components are configured in the correct order, that dependencies between steps are respected, and that the final implementation is complete, coherent, and verifiable.

Step 01	**Prepare the Employee Data File** Create a structured data file in Google Sheets or Microsoft Excel containing all employee records. Ensure the file includes the following five columns: Name, Email, Department, Manager, and Manager Email. Validate all entries for completeness, formatting consistency, and the absence of duplicate email addresses. Export the completed file in XLSX or CSV format in preparation for upload to ServiceNow.
Step	**Import Data Using ServiceNow Import Sets**

02

Log into the ServiceNow administrator interface and navigate to the System Import Sets module. Use the Load Data function to upload the prepared employee data file and create a new Import Set staging table. Verify that the Import Set table has been created correctly and that all records and column fields are accurately reflected in the staging environment before proceeding to the next step.

Step **03**

Create and Configure the Transform Map

Navigate to the Transform Maps section within the System Import Sets module and create a new Transform Map. Assign the Import Set staging table as the source and the sys_user table as the target. Provide the Transform Map with a clear, descriptive name and save the initial configuration before proceeding to the field mapping stage.

Step **04**

Map Fields Between Source and Target Tables

Within the Transform Map, create Field Map entries for each required data field. Use the Auto Map Matching Fields function where field names are consistent between the source and target, and manually create mappings for fields that require explicit configuration. Designate the email field as the coalesce key to ensure that existing records are updated rather than duplicated during repeated import operations. Review all field mappings carefully before proceeding.

Step **05**

Implement Dot Walking for Derived Fields

Configure Dot Walking expressions within the appropriate Field Map entries to enable the automatic retrieval of derived field values. Specifically, configure the manager.email Dot Walk expression to automatically populate the Manager Email field by traversing the manager reference relationship in the sys_user table. Verify that the Dot Walk expressions are syntactically correct and that the referenced tables contain the required records for resolution.

Step **06**

Apply Dictionary Override for the Priority Field

Navigate to the System Definition Dictionary module and locate the Priority field on the Incident table. Create a Dictionary Override entry for this field to customize its default value in accordance with the organization's incident management policy. Test the override by creating a sample incident record and confirming that the default priority value reflects the customized setting rather than the system default.

Step **07**

Execute Transformation and Validate Results

Return to the Import Set and execute the transformation process by selecting the configured Transform Map and initiating the Transform operation. Upon completion, review the transformation log for any errors or warnings. Navigate

to the User Administration module and inspect the imported user records to confirm that all fields — including Name, Email, Department, Manager, and Manager Email — are correctly populated. Verify Dot Walking output and the Dictionary Override configuration, and address any identified issues before concluding the implementation.

9.1 Workflow Dependencies

The following dependencies between workflow steps must be observed to ensure the implementation proceeds correctly:

- Step 01 must be completed before Step 02, as the Import Set cannot be created without a valid data file to upload.
- Step 02 must be completed before Step 03, as the Transform Map requires an existing Import Set staging table to be designated as the source.
- Step 03 must be completed before Step 04, as field mappings are created within the context of a saved Transform Map.
- Step 04 must be completed before Step 05, as Dot Walking expressions are configured within specific Field Map entries that must first exist within the Transform Map.
- Steps 03 through 05 must all be completed before Step 07, as the transformation operation applies the entire Transform Map — including all field mappings and Dot Walking expressions — to the Import Set data.
- Step 06 (Dictionary Override) is independent of Steps 02 through 05 and may be performed at any point after Step 03, but must be completed before the final validation in Step 07.

— End of Project Planning Phase Document —

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